new challenge to the American Boeing had just had its first commercial flight.

Sud Aviation, which later became Aerospatiale with the merger of Nord Aviation in 1970, was leading the consortium that made Airbus. The genesis was the annual Paris Air Show of 1965, where aviation industry giants across Europe floated the idea of making an alternative to Boeing, which then had the monopoly of the passenger aircraft sector.

By 1967, Airbus A300 was ready with a plan of synergy among the European sisters: Sud Aviation (France) would make the cockpit, flight control and the lower centre section of the fusealage; Hawker Siddeley (UK) the wings; Deutsche Airbus (Germany) the front and rear parts of the fuselage; Fokker-VFW (Dutch) the flaps and spoilers; and a Spanish company the horizontal tailplane. Rolls-Royce would make the engine.

Despite politics and financial concerns by participant governments, Airbus became a reality within five years. A300 made its maiden flight in 1972, and a slightly modified version, (A300B2) was in service by 1974. The consortium badly needed orders from countries outside Europe, and India was looking for a small new fleet of seven or so aircraft for Indian Airlines.

Then Prime Minister Indira Gandhi had appointed Satish Dhawan, the ISRO chairman, as the committee to choose between Airbus and Boeing. It was around this time that Aerospatiale technical head Delvel approached me. He was pretty straight forward with the proposal, ‘You get me the Indian contract for Airbus, I will get you the technology from SEP that is not covered under your Viking contract.’

It was an offer too difficult to refuse, but I could only tell Dhawan who knew better than me how the stage technology transfer would immensely benefit India, and speed up the PSLV project. I knew Dhawan would make his selection between Boeing and Airbus purely on the merit of the aircraft, and would not allow the French promise of technology transfer of systems outside the Viking contract to interfere with his decision.

So I put it forward to Dhawan thus, ‘If, after the due process—with no influence from anyone whatsoever—you select Airbus, would you allow